

Dials—but he wanted badly to know who № 7 was. He got himself asked to the Cootes under the impression that Sir Oswald Cootie was № 7.

‘I suspected Sir Oswald,’ said Bundle, ‘especially when he came in from the garden that night.’

‘I never suspected him,’ said Battle. ‘But I don’t mind telling you that I *did* have my suspicions of that young chap, his secretary.’

‘Pongo?’ said Bill. ‘Not old Pongo?’

‘Yes, Mr Eversleigh, old Pongo as you call him. A very efficient gentleman and one that could have put anything through if he’d a mind to. I suspected him partly because he’d been the one to take the clocks into Mr Wade’s room that night. It would have been easy for him to put the bottle and glass by the bedside then. And then, for another thing, he was left-handed. That glove pointed straight to him—if it hadn’t been for one thing—’

‘What?’

‘The teeth marks—only a man whose right hand was incapacitated would have needed to tear off that glove with his teeth.’

‘So Pongo was cleared.’

‘So Pongo was cleared, as you say. I’m sure it would be a great surprise to Mr Bateman to know he was ever suspected.’

‘It would,’ agreed Bill. ‘A solemn card—a silly ass like Pongo. How you could ever think—’

‘Well, as far as that goes, Mr Thesiger was what you might describe as an empty-headed young ass of the most brainless description. One of the two was playing a part. When I decided that it was Mr Thesiger, I was interested to get Mr Bateman’s opinion of him. All along, Mr Bateman had the gravest suspicions of Mr Thesiger and frequently said as much to Sir Oswald.’

‘It’s curious,’ said Bill, ‘but Pongo always is right. It’s maddening.’

‘Well, as I say,’ went on Superintendent Battle, ‘we got Mr Thesiger fairly on the run, badly rattled over this Seven Dials business and uncertain just where the danger lay. That we got him in the end was solely through Mr Eversleigh. He knew what he was up against, and he risked his life cheerfully. But he never dreamt that you would be dragged into it, Lady Eileen.’

‘My God, no,’ said Bill with feeling.

‘He went round to Mr Thesiger’s rooms with a cooked-up tale,’ continued Battle. ‘He was to pretend that certain papers of Mr Devereux’s had come into his hands. Those papers were to suggest a suspicion of Mr Thesiger. Naturally, as the honest friend, Mr Eversleigh rushed round, sure that Mr Thesiger would have an explanation. We calculated that if we were right, Mr Thesiger would try and put Mr Eversleigh out of the way, and we were fairly certain as to the way he’d do it. Sure enough, Mr Thesiger gave his guest a whisky and soda. During the minute or two that his host was out of the room, Mr Eversleigh poured that into a jar on the mantelpiece, but he had to pretend, of course, that the drug was taking effect. It would be slow, he knew, not sudden. He began his story, and Mr Thesiger at first denied it all indignantly, but as soon as he saw (or thought he saw) that the drug was taking effect, he admitted everything and told Mr Eversleigh that he was the third victim.’

When Mr Eversleigh was nearly unconscious, Mr Thesiger took him down to the car and helped him in. The hood was up. He must already have telephoned to you unknown to Mr Eversleigh. He made a clever suggestion to you. You were to say that you were taking Miss Wade home.

You made no mention of a message from him. Later, when your body was found here, Miss Wade would swear that you had driven her home and gone up to London with the idea of penetrating into this house by yourself.

Mr Eversleigh continued to play his part, that of the unconscious man. I may say that as soon as the two young men had left Jermyn Street, one of my men gained admission and found the doctored whisky, which contained enough hydrochloride of morphia to kill two men. Also the car they were in was followed. Mr Thesiger drove out of town to a well-known golf course, where he showed himself for a few minutes, speaking of playing a round. That, of course, was for an alibi, should one be needed. He left the car with Mr Eversleigh in it a little way down the road. Then he drove back to town and to the Seven Dials Club. As soon as he saw Alfred leave, he drove up to the door, spoke to Mr Eversleigh as he got out in case you might be listening and came into the house and played his little comedy.

When he pretended to go for a doctor, he really only slammed the door and then crept quietly upstairs and hid behind the door of this

room, where Miss Wade would presently send you up on some excuse. Mr Eversleigh, of course, was horror struck when he saw you, but he thought it best to keep up the part he was playing. He knew our people were watching the house, and he imagined that there was no immediate danger intended to you. He could always 'come to life' at any moment. When Mr Thesiger threw his revolver on the table and apparently left the house it seemed safer than ever. As for the next bit—' He paused, looking at Bill. 'Perhaps you'd like to tell that, sir.'

'I was still lying on that bally sofa,' said Bill, 'trying to look done in and getting the fidgets worse and worse. Then I heard someone run down the stairs, and Loraine got up and went to the door. I heard Thesiger's voice, but not what he said. I heard Loraine say: "That's all right—it's gone splendidly." Then he said: "Help me carry him up. It will be a bit of a job, but I want them both together there—a nice little surprise for № 7." I didn't quite understand what they were jawing about, but they hauled me up the stairs somehow or other. It was a bit of a job for them. I made myself a dead weight all right. They heaved me in here, and then I heard Loraine say: "You're sure it's all right. She won't come round?" And Jimmy said—the damned blackguard: "No fear. I hit with all my might."'

'They went away and locked the door, and then I opened my eyes and saw you. My God, Bundle, I shall never feel so perfectly awful again. I thought you were dead.'

'I suppose my hat saved me,' said Bundle.

'Partly,' said Superintendent Bartle. 'But partly it was Mr Thesiger's wounded arm. He didn't realize it himself—but it had only half its usual strength. Still, that's all no credit to the Department. We didn't take the care of you we ought to have done, Lady Eileen—and it's a black blot on the whole business.'

'I'm very tough,' said Bundle. 'And also rather lucky. What I can't get over is Loraine being in it. She was such a gentle little thing.'

'Ah,' said the Superintendent. 'So was the Pentonville murderess that killed five children. You can't go by that. She's got bad blood in her—her father ought to have seen the inside of a prison more than once.'

'You've got her too?'
Superintendent Bartle nodded.

about, speak in your own voice and then in a hoarse half-whisper. And then, the final touch, the two revolver shots. His own Colt automatic, bought openly the day before, is fired at an imaginary assailant. Then, with his left gloved hand, he takes from his pocket the small Mauser pistol and shoots himself through the fleshy part of the right arm. He flings the pistol through the window, tears off the glove with his teeth, and throws it into the fire. When I arrive he is lying on the floor in a faint.'

Bundle drew a deep breath.

'You didn't realize all this at the time, Superintendent Bartle?'

'No, that I didn't. I was taken in as much as anyone could be. It wasn't till long afterwards that I pieced it all together. Finding the glove was the beginning of it. Then I made Sir Oswald throw the pistol through the window. It fell a good way farther on than it should have done. But a man who is right-handed doesn't throw nearly as far with the left hand. Even then it was only suspicion—and a very faint suspicion at that.

But there was one point struck me. The papers were obviously thrown down for someone to pick up. If Miss Wade was there by accident, who was the real person? Of course, for those who weren't in the know, that question was answered easily enough—the Countess. But there I had the pull over you. *I knew the Countess was all right*. So what follows? Why, the idea that the papers had actually been picked up by the person they were meant for. And the more I thought of it, the more it seemed to me a very remarkable coincidence that Miss Wade should have arrived at the exact moment she did.'

'It must have been very difficult for you when I came to you full of suspicion about the Countess.'

'It was, Lady Eileen. I had to say something to put you off the scent. And it was very difficult for Mr Eversleigh here, with the lady coming out of a dead faint and no knowing what she might say.'

'I understand Bill's anxiety now,' said Bundle. 'And the way he kept urging her to take time and not talk till she felt quite all right.'

'Poor old Bill,' said Miss St Maur. 'That poor baby had to be ramped against his will—getting madder in a hornet every minute.'

'Well,' said Superintendent Bartle, 'there it was. I suspected Mr Thesiger—but I couldn't get definite proof. On the other hand, Mr Thesiger himself was rattled. He realized more or less what he was up against in the Seven

I found the burnt glove in the fireplace with the teeth marks on it—and then—well—I knew that I'd been right after all. But, upon my word, he was a clever one.'

'What actually happened?' said Bundle. 'Who was the other man?'

'There wasn't any other man. Listen, and I'll show you how in the end I reconstructed the whole story. To begin with, Mr Thesiger and Miss Wade are in this together. And they have a rendezvous for an exact time. Miss Wade comes over in her car, climbs through the fence and comes up to the house. She's got a perfectly good story if any one stops her—the one she told eventually. But she arrived unmolested on the terrace just after the clock had struck two.

Now, I may say to begin with that she was seen coming in. My men saw her, but they had orders to stop nobody coming in—only going out. I wanted, you see, to find out as much as possible. Miss Wade arrives on the terrace, and at that minute a parcel falls at her feet and she picks it up. A man comes down the ivy and she starts to run. What happens next? The struggle—and presently the revolver shots. What will everyone do? Rush to the scene of the fight. And Miss Loraine Wade could have left the grounds and driven off with the formula safely in her possession.

But things don't happen quite like that. Miss Wade runs straight into my arms. And at that moment the game changes. It's no longer attack but defence. Miss Wade tells her story. It is perfectly true and perfectly sensible.

And now we come to Mr Thesiger. One thing struck me at once. The bullet wound alone couldn't have caused him to faint. Either he had fallen and hit his head—or—well, he hadn't fainted at all. Later we had Miss St Maur's story. It agreed perfectly with Mr Thesiger's—there was only one suggestive point. Miss St Maur said that after the lights were turned out and Mr Thesiger went over to the window, he was so still that she thought he must have left the room and gone outside. Now, if any one is in the room, you can hardly help hearing their breathing if you are listening for it. Supposing, then, that Mr Thesiger *had* gone outside. Where next? Up the ivy to Mr O'Rourke's room—Mr O'Rourke's whisky and soda having been doped the night before. He gets the papers, throws them down to the girl, climbs down the ivy again, and—starts the fight. That's easy enough when you come to think of it. Knock the tables down, stagger

'I daresay they won't hang her—juries are soft-hearted. But young Thesiger will swing all right—and a good thing too—a more utterly depraved and callous criminal I never met.

And now,' he added. 'If your head isn't aching too badly, Lady Eileen. What about a little celebration? There's a nice little restaurant round the corner.'

Bundle heartily agreed.

'I'm starving, Superintendent Battle. Besides,' she looked round, 'I've got to get to know all my colleagues.'

'The Seven Dials,' said Bill. 'Hurrah! Some fizz is what we need. Do they run to fizz at this place, Battle?'

'You won't have anything to complain of, sir. You leave it to me.'

'Superintendent Battle,' said Bundle, 'you are a wonderful man. I'm sorry you're married already. As it is, I shall have to put up with Bill.'

do anything he told her. She passed on the information to him. In the same way, later, Mr Devereux was attracted to her, and probably warned her against Mr Thesiger. So Mr Devereux in turn was silenced—and died trying to send word to the Seven Dials that his murderer was Mr Thesiger.’

‘How ghastly,’ cried Bundle. ‘If I had only known.’

‘Well, it didn’t seem likely. In fact, I could hardly credit it myself. But then we came to the affair at the Abbey. You will remember how awkward it was—specially awkward for Mr Eversleigh here. You and Mr Thesiger were hand in glove. Mr Eversleigh had already been embarrassed by your insisting on being brought to this place, and when he found that you had actually overheard what went on at a meeting, he was dumfounded.’

The Superintendent paused and a twinkle came into his eye.

‘So was I, Lady Eileen. I never dreamt of such a thing being possible. You put one over on me there all right.’

Well, Mr Eversleigh was in a dilemma. He couldn’t let you into the secret of the Seven Dials without letting Mr Thesiger in also—and that would never do. It all suited Mr Thesiger very well, of course, for it gave him a bona fide reason for getting himself asked to the Abbey; which made things much easier for him.

I may say that the Seven Dials had already sent a warning letter to Mr Lomax. That was to ensure his applying to me for assistance, so that I should be able to be on the spot in a perfectly natural manner. I made no secret of my presence, as you know.’

And again the Superintendent’s eyes twinkled.

‘Well, ostensibly, Mr Eversleigh and Mr Thesiger were to divide the night into two watches. Really, Mr Eversleigh and Miss St Maur did so. She was on guard at the library window when she heard Mr Thesiger coming and had to dart behind the screen.’

And now comes the cleverness of Mr Thesiger. Up to a point he told a perfectly true story, and I must admit that with the fight and everything, I was distinctly shaken—and began to wonder whether he had had anything to do with the theft at all, or whether we were completely on the wrong track. There were one or two suspicious circumstances that pointed in an entirely different direction, and I can tell you I didn’t know what to make of things, when something turned up to clinch matters.

house must actually be the criminal we were all after. He came, I think, very near confiding in Mr Thesiger, for he certainly had no suspicions of him at that moment. But something held him back.

Then he did rather a curious thing. He arranged seven clocks upon the mantelpiece, throwing away the eighth. It was meant as a symbol that the Seven Dials would revenge the death of one of their members—and he watched eagerly to see if anyone betrayed themselves or showed signs of perturbation.

‘And it was Jimmy Thesiger who poisoned Gerry Wade?’

‘Yes, he slipped the stuff into a whisky and soda which Mr Wade had downstairs before retiring to bed. That’s why he was already feeling sleepy when he wrote that letter to Miss Wade.’

‘Then the footman, Bauer, hadn’t anything to do with it?’ asked Bundle.

‘Bauer was one of our people, Lady Eileen. It was thought likely that our crook would go for Herr Eberhard’s invention and Bauer was got into the house to watch events on our behalf. But he wasn’t able to do much. As I say, Mr Thesiger administered the fatal dose easily enough. Later, when everyone was asleep, a bottle, glass and empty chloral bottle were placed by Mr Wade’s bedside by Mr Thesiger. Mr Wade was unconscious then, and his fingers were probably pressed round the glass and the bottle so that they should be found there if any questions should arise. I don’t know what effect the seven clocks on the mantelpiece made on Mr Thesiger. He certainly didn’t let on anything to Mr Devereux. All the same, I think he had a bad five minutes now and again thinking of them. And I think he kept a pretty wary eye on Mr Devereux after that.

We don’t know exactly what happened next. No one saw much of Mr Devereux after Mr Wade’s death. But it is clear that he worked along the same lines that he knew Mr Wade had been working on and reached the same result—namely, that Mr Thesiger was the man. I fancy, too, that he was betrayed in the same way.’

‘You mean?’

‘Through Miss Loraine Wade. Mr Wade was devoted to her—I believe he hoped to marry her—she wasn’t really his sister, of course—and there is no doubt that he told her more than he should have done. But Miss Loraine Wade was devoted body and soul to Mr Thesiger. She would

Chapter XXXIV

Lord Caterham Approves

‘FATHER,’ said Bundle, ‘I’ve got to break a piece of news to you. You’re going to lose me.’

‘Nonsense,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘Don’t tell me that you’re suffering from galloping consumption or a weak heart or anything like that, because I simply don’t believe it.’

‘It’s not death,’ said Bundle. ‘It’s marriage.’

‘Very nearly as bad,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘I suppose I shall have to come to the wedding, all dressed up in tight, uncomfortable clothes, and give you away. And Lomax may think it necessary to kiss me in the vestry.’

‘Good heavens! You don’t think I’m going to marry George, do you?’ cried Bundle.

‘Well, something like that seemed to be in the wind last time I saw you,’ said her father. ‘Yesterday morning, you know.’

‘I’m going to be married to someone a hundred times nicer than George,’ said Bundle.

‘I hope so, I’m sure,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘But one never knows. I don’t feel you’re really a good judge of character, Bundle. You told me that young Thesiger was a cheerful inefficient, and from all I hear now it seems that he was one of the most efficient criminals of the day. The sad thing is that I never met him. I was thinking of writing my reminiscences soon—with a special chapter on murderers I have met—and by a purely technical oversight, I never met this young man.’

‘Don’t be silly,’ said Bundle. ‘You know you haven’t got the energy to write reminiscences or anything else.’

‘I wasn’t actually going to write them myself,’ said Lord Caterham. ‘I believe that’s never done. But I met a very charming girl the other day

and that's her special job. She collects the material and does all the actual writing.'

'And what do you do?'

'Oh, just give her a few facts for half an hour every day. Nothing more than that.' After a slight pause, Lord Caterham said: 'She was a nice-looking girl—very restful and sympathetic.'

'Father,' said Bundle, 'I have a feeling that without me you will run into deadly danger.'

'Different kinds of danger suit different kinds of people,' said Lord Caterham.

He was moving away, when he turned back and said over his shoulder:

'By the way, Bundle, who *are* you marrying?'

'I was wondering,' said Bundle, 'when you were going to ask me that. I'm going to marry Bill Eversleigh.'

The egoist thought it over for a minute. Then he nodded in complete satisfaction.

'Excellent,' he said. 'He's scratch, isn't he? He and I can play together in the foursomes in the Autumn Meeting.'

Chapter XXXIII

Battle Explains



UPERINTENDENT Battle settled to explain. He spoke comfortably and cosily.

'I didn't suspect him myself for a long time. The first hint of it I had was when I heard what Mr Devereux's last words had been. Naturally, you took them to mean that Mr Devereux was trying to send word to Mr Thesiger that the Seven Dials had killed him. That's what the words seemed to mean on their face value. But of course I knew that that couldn't be so. It was the Seven Dials that Mr Devereux wanted told—and what he wanted them told was something about Mr Jimmy Thesiger.

The thing seemed incredible, because Mr Devereux and Mr Thesiger were close friends. But I remembered something else—that these thefts must have been committed by someone who was absolutely in the know. Someone who, if not in the Foreign Office himself, was in the way of hearing all its chit-chat. And I found it very hard to find out where Mr Thesiger got his money. The income his father left him was a small one, yet he was able to live at a most expensive rate. Where did the money come from?

I knew that Mr Wade had been very excited by something that he had found out. He was quite sure that he was on the right track. He didn't confide in anyone about what he thought that track was, but he did say something to Mr Devereux about being on the point of making sure. That was just before they both went down to Chimneys for that weekend. As you know, Mr Wade died there—apparently from an overdose of a sleeping draught. It seemed straightforward enough, but Mr Devereux did not accept that explanation for a minute. He was convinced that Mr Wade had been very cleverly put out of the way and that someone in the

Colophon

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‘It’s—it’s not been just fun. You see, I was kinder engaged to Ronny, and when he handed in his checks—well, I had to do something to track down the skunk who murdered him. That’s all.’

‘I’m completely bewildered,’ said Bundle. ‘Nothing is what it seems.’

‘It’s very simple, Lady Eileen,’ said Superintendent Batte. ‘It began with some of the young people wanting a bit of excitement. It was Mr Wade who first got on to me. He suggested the formation of a band of what you might call amateur workers to do a bit of secret service work. I warned him that it might be dangerous—but he wasn’t the kind to weigh that in the balance. I made it plain to him that any one who came in must do so on that understanding. But, bless you, that wasn’t going to stop any of Mr Wade’s friends. And so the thing began.’

‘But what was the object of it all?’ asked Bundle.

‘We wanted a certain man—wanted him badly. He wasn’t an ordinary crook. He worked in Mr Wade’s world, a kind of Raffles, but much more dangerous than any Raffles ever was or could be. He was out for big stuff, international stuff. Twice already valuable secret inventions had been stolen, and clearly stolen by someone who had inside knowledge. The professionals had had a try—and failed. Then the amateurs took on—and succeeded.’

‘Succeeded?’

‘Yes—but they didn’t come out of it unscathed. The man was dangerous. Two lives fell victim to him and he got away with it. But the Seven Dials stuck to it. And as I say, they succeeded. Thanks to Mr Eversleigh, the man was caught at last red-handed.’

‘Who was he?’ asked Bundle. ‘Do I know him?’

‘You know him very well, Lady Eileen. His name is Mr Jimmy Theisger, and he was arrested this afternoon.’